

which seemed to suggest a possible way forward with the rich invention and artistic purity of their unaccompanied choral works.

A crucial breakthrough came from another quite different area of interest. Vaughan Williams, Holst, and their fellow composer George Butterworth went out into England's villages and countryside to collect the local folk songs that they heard there, spurred on by the reality that these were literally dying out: Britain's industrialization during the 19th century had emptied the countryside of much of its population—and with it, a whole tradition of unaccompanied singing. This had sprung up on the basis that the majority of people who were living and working on the land were much too poor to own an instrument, so that in musical terms, singing was all they had.

Vaughan Williams found himself deeply drawn to folk music's sense of freedom and naturalness. The challenge was to find a successful way of bringing these qualities, and also those of English Tudor and Elizabethan church music, into the sophisticated world of the classical concert hall. The quest lasted for many years, and took in a period of study in Paris with Ravel. Although Vaughan Williams was the older of the two composers, he sensed that the chance to acquire “a little French polish,” as he put it, from Ravel's technical mastery was a useful counterbalance to the German-dominated side of musical tradition.